

dering if they would benefit from a separate trust, or if you should take out a loan for their further education or buy more life insurance.

Perhaps because of these constant daily reminders of financial opportunity, everything in and around the house has become an investment, including the occupants. This I discovered as I took a complete personal inventory before embarking on my journey.

What used to be known as acquaintances, relatives, children, husbands, and wives have all become investments. A few years ago—though I'm not certain when—we began calling children "our investments in the future." Soon we found ourselves investing in their education, which used to be called putting them through school. Some people invest in relationships, as opposed to just having friends over for dinner. My wife, of course, is a perpetual investment, as I am to her. It's also possible to invest in pets and sell the offspring, though I doubt we could pay anybody to take our cats.

Lately, I've begun to think of the hereafter as the Keogh plan and life after death as the tax-deferred IRA. Once I regarded my car as simple transportation, and now it is a depreciated holding. The roof over our heads has become an inflation hedge, next-to-useless during a deflationary cycle. Every other week we're debating whether to sell out or stay, whether to refinance or hold out for lower rates, whether to rent the place and move into something with a bigger mortgage-interest deduction.

The dining room table is a fixed asset; the dishes set down upon it are collectibles. The smart money, I realize now, would have divested the dishes in the early 1980s, when collectibles were at a premium, and gone into paper plates. The last spike in silver prices destroyed all feelings of loyalty for the family flatware, which now serves only as a painful reminder of our missed opportunity to cash in at \$41 an ounce. Ditto the silver backgammon cube, which I transported to the safe-deposit box but which is no longer worth protecting.

The silver samovar is corroded, but we maintain it in spite of no sign of inflation. Its ultimate purpose may depend on whether the Federal Reserve continues to lower the discount rate. Looking through our closets, I see dozens of examples of poor market